

ST. MORITZ: RISKY FUN • BODYGUARD ETIQUETTE • GREAT BLACK TIE

DECEMBER 1985 \$3.00

M

THE CIVILIZED MAN



CIVILIZED FUN

At Cambridge, where they like to have a morning punt after a night's revel



DIABOLICAL DEALING: SELLING "GREAT SATAN'S" GUNS TO THE AYATOLLAH

Although Iran's Ayatollah Khomeini and his adherents consider the U.S. to be the "Great Satan," the current Iranian regime evidently still is prepared to pay millions of diabolical dollars to American businessmen and military contractors to obtain illicitly the satanic spare parts, ammunition and weapons its military forces need to prosecute Iran's interminable Persian Gulf war with neighboring Iraq.

Despite stringent U.S. embargos on trade with Iran which have been in effect since the 1980 Tehran embassy hostage crisis, American businessmen—and in some cases wayward American military personnel—have played a major role in keeping Khomeini's ramshackle and beleaguered military machine, equipped under the late Shah with luxuriant quantities of American equipment, afloat.

According to William von Raab, commissioner of the U.S. Customs Service, which investigates illegal arms traffic, the Khomeini regime has abandoned Islamic principles and turned to its implacable foe for weapons and spares because "they're desperate."

"They've cannibalized existing equipment all they can. In the U.S., a new generation of weapons has already been developed and so the parts the Iranians need for their old equipment are becoming obsolete. So they have to get them now or face the problem of trying to buy new equipment."

The U.S. government still bans exports not only of weapons but all military-



The Ayatollah is willing to pay millions to Americans to buy men like this equipment...



...which gets hard use in the continuing war with Iraq.

related equipment—including spare parts that could be used for both civilian and military aircraft—to Iran. So any attempts by the Iranians to buy such material from the U.S. are strictly verboten. But the Khomeini regime's agents have let it be known in the American defense industry that money is no problem for weapons dealers who are willing to risk heavy fines and long prison terms. A lengthening American court docket of Iranian arms smuggling cases indicates there are numerous enterprising individuals in the U.S. ready to accept Khomeini's cash.

The last two years have been particularly busy for American law enforcement agents responsible for enforcing the Iranian arms embargo. Investigators from the Customs Service and the FBI have broken up several major Iranian arms and spare parts smuggling operations, including some with impressive connections inside the U.S. government.

- In August, Customs agents and the FBI arrested five men and a woman on charges of attempting to purchase for Khomeini such big-ticket items as Sidewinder, Sparrow, Phoenix and Harpoon missiles and parts for American-made F-4 fighter jets. The apparent mastermind of the arms ring was a military affairs writer, Paul Cutter, who claimed to deal directly with the Iranian minister of procurement. Cutter employed an active duty officer assigned to the U.S. Army Missile Command at the Pentagon, Lt. Col Wayne Gillespie, as a "missile inspector" for the smuggling operation, according to court documents. Indicted along



At the start of the Iran/Iraq war, Iraqi soldier watches Iranian airport after bombing



Customs commissioner von Raab

with Cutter, Gillespie and three California businessmen was Amir Hosseini, a self-described official of the Iranian government who had visited the U.S.

- In late July, a Federal grand jury in San Diego indicted seven people on charges of conspiring to ship to Iran what prosecutor Phil Halpern describes as some of the "most sophisticated combat weaponry known to the free world." This included critical electronic components for the F-14 fighter jet, which the U.S. sold to the Shah as the mainstay of his air force. According to the indictment, some of the equipment shipped to the Iranians was stolen from U.S. aircraft carriers and stateside military installations by active-duty sailors, who were among those charged.

- Last year, three Iranian brothers, Cyrus, Reza and Djamshid Hashemi, were indicted in New York for conspiring to violate the U.S. arms embargo before and after the 1980 hostage crisis. U.S. Customs wanted to arrest the Hashemis so badly



Federal agents with a cache of confiscated arms, including MAC/10 submachine guns with silencers (on table)

that an undercover "sting" operation was set up to try to lure Reza Hashemi, who was in Europe, back to the U.S. This "sting" succeeded and Reza Hashemi recently pleaded guilty in New York to export control violations. But Djamshid Hashemi managed to flee the U.S., avoiding arrest, after an alleged tip-off from friends in the CIA, and Cyrus Hashemi has not visited the U.S. since his indictment. One or more of the brothers over the years have retained influential American lawyers, including former Attor-

ney General Elliott Richardson and J. Stanley Pottinger, a former senior Justice Department official in the Nixon administration.

American officials responsible for keeping Iranian arms traffickers in check say that when the American arms embargo first took effect, the Iranians were fairly unsophisticated about whom they approached in the U.S. to help them smuggle equipment past American authorities. As a consequence, some of the weapons merchants approached by Iranian agents reportedly

took Khomeini's money and ran. More recently, the Iranians are finding a more reliable network of businessmen to serve their needs.

Khomeini is still helped, however, by the fact that he has a substantial following within the still-large community of Iranians in America. This Islamic fifth column not only provides the Ayatollah with a reliable network of sympathizers who can provide background support for arms deals, but also gives the Iranians the capability of mounting terrorist attacks inside the U.S. if they so desire. As many as 1,000 pro-Khomeini Iranians currently are under surveillance by the FBI, according to government sources. "There are many Iranian terrorism scares" inside the U.S., says Dr. Robert Kupperman, executive director of the Georgetown Center for Strategic and International Studies.

Up until now, however, the Iranians have refrained from biting the American hands that feed their military machine.

—MARK HOSENBALL